Socialists Turned into Nationalists

When Left Strategy Encourages Nationalist Emergence

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Washington University in St. Louis

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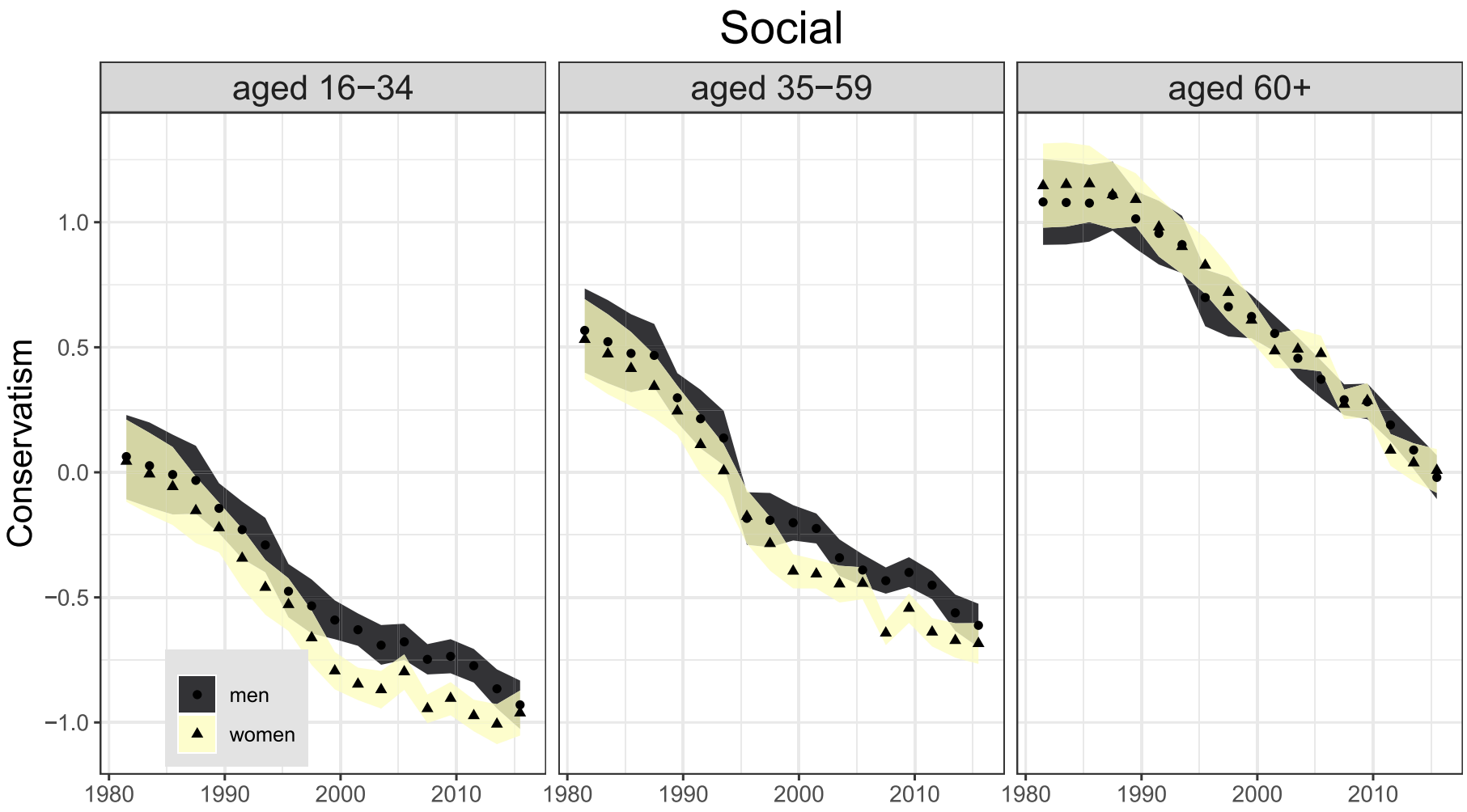
Why is he laughing?

Nationalist Emergence in Liberal Europe



Source: Caughey et al. 2019

Liberal Voters and Conservative Outcome

- Conservatives support nationalists
  (e.g. Ivarsflaten 2008)
- Weak translation into macro-level outcomes
- Why? Parties respond to changes in demands

Less conservatives
More liberals

$\Rightarrow$
?

Nationalist
Emergence

Mainstream Party Strategy

Less conservatives
More liberals

$\Rightarrow$
$+$

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Party incentive:
Target liberals

Mainstream Party Strategy

Less conservatives
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Nationalist
Emergence

Party incentive:
Target liberals

$\rightarrow$ Conservatives unhappy with existing parties

Modeling Party Response to Changes in Demands

- Multidimensional nature of competition

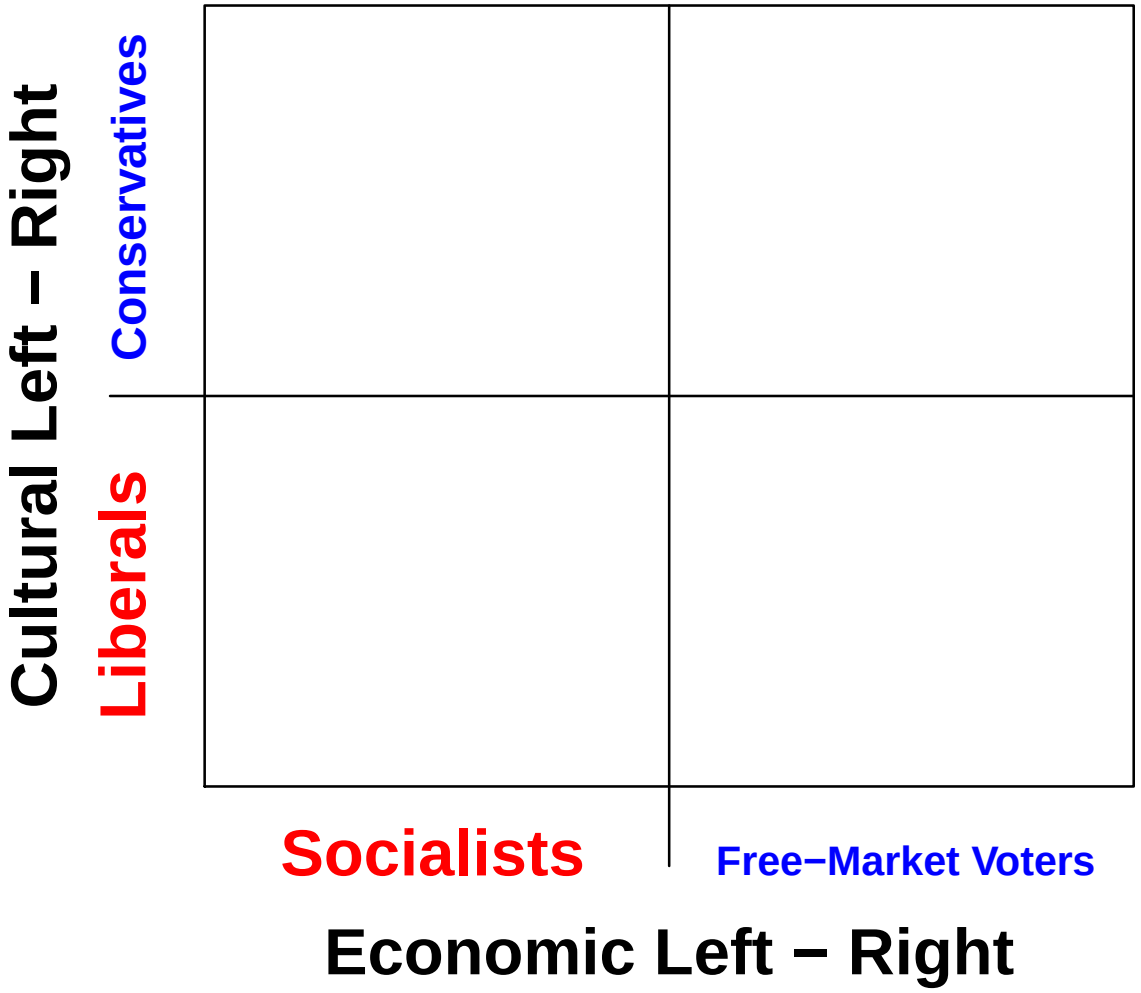
  - Nationalists specialize in cultural issues

- Issue emphasis (Tavits and Potter 2015):

  - Weights on dimensions, but different weights for each party

- When do nationalists enter the election (Palfrey 1984), given issue emphasis of parties?

Policy Emphasis and Voter Preference



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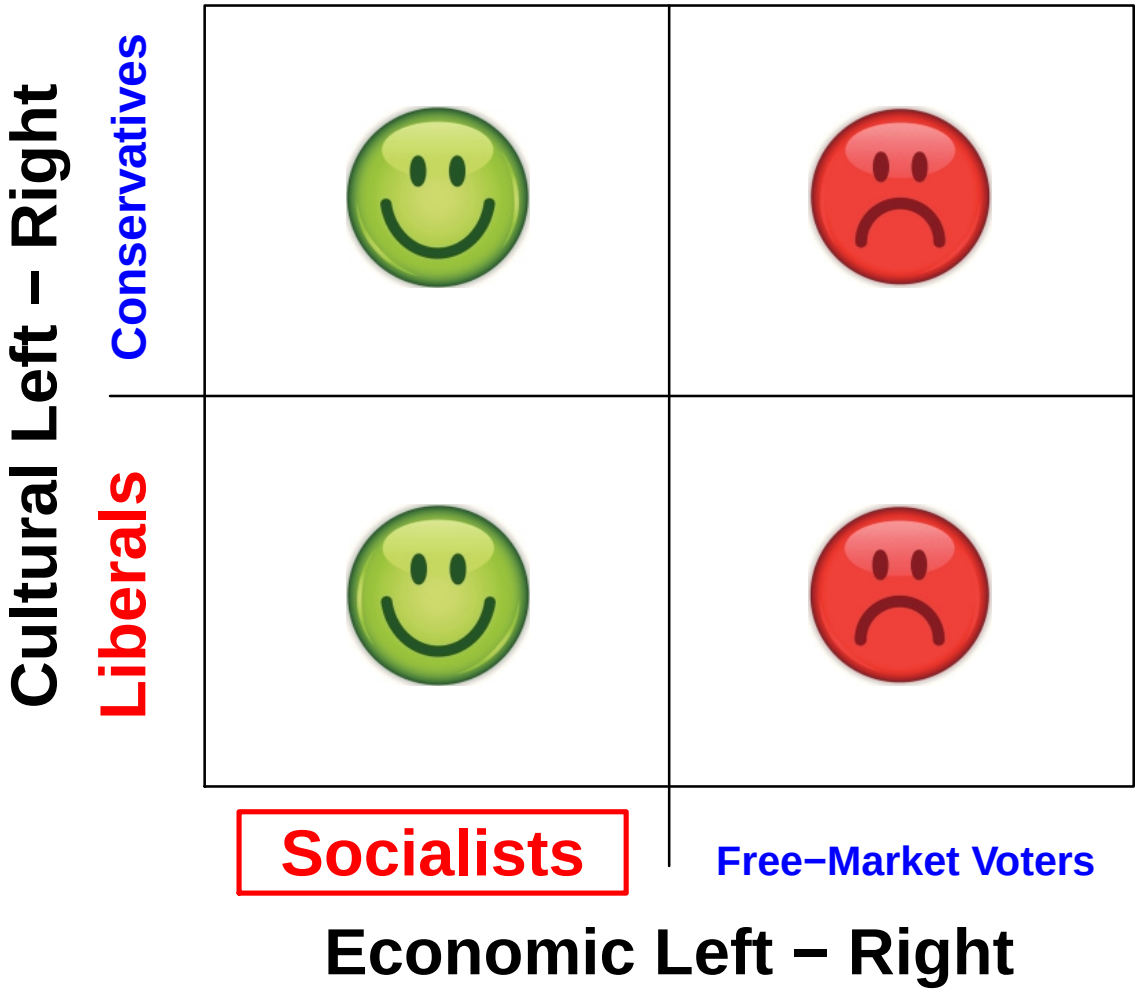

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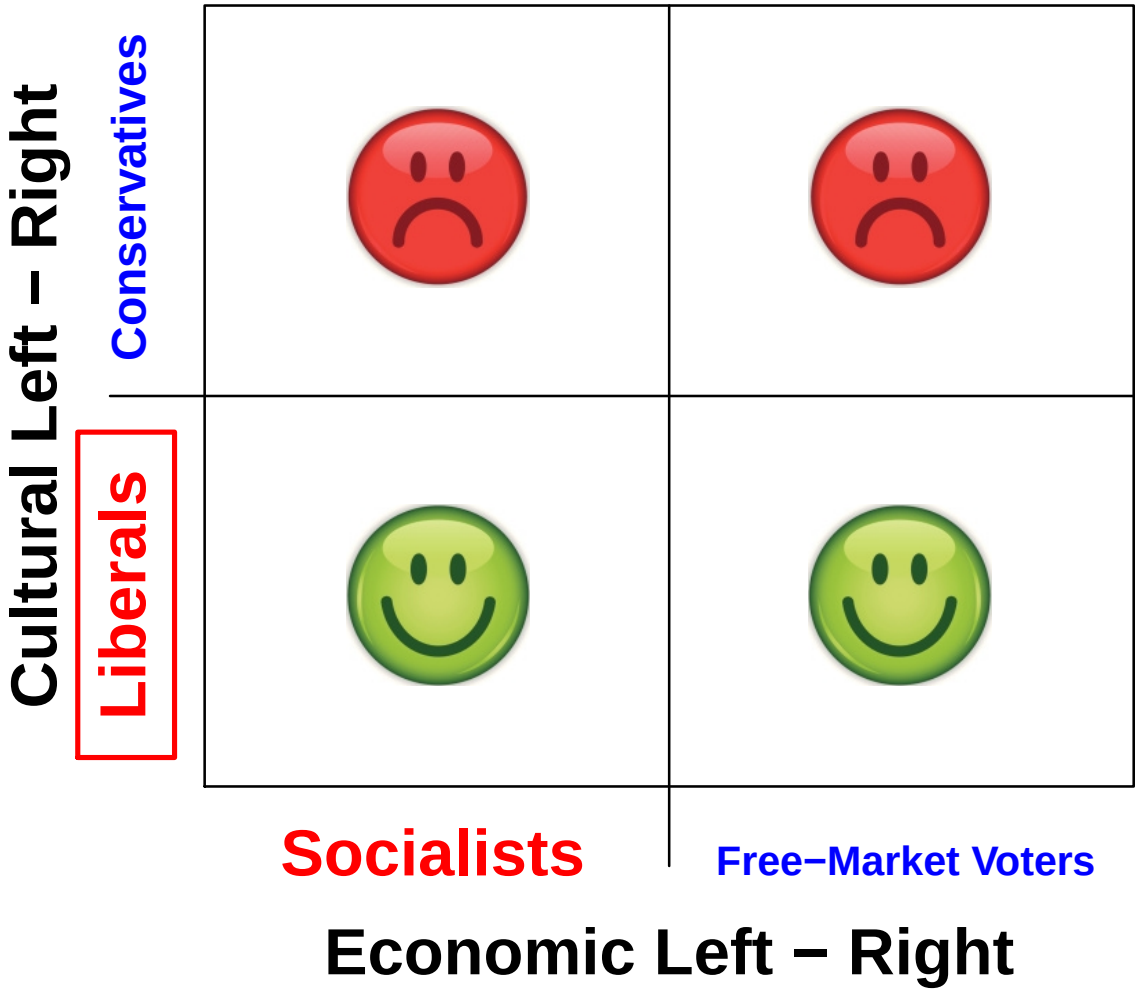

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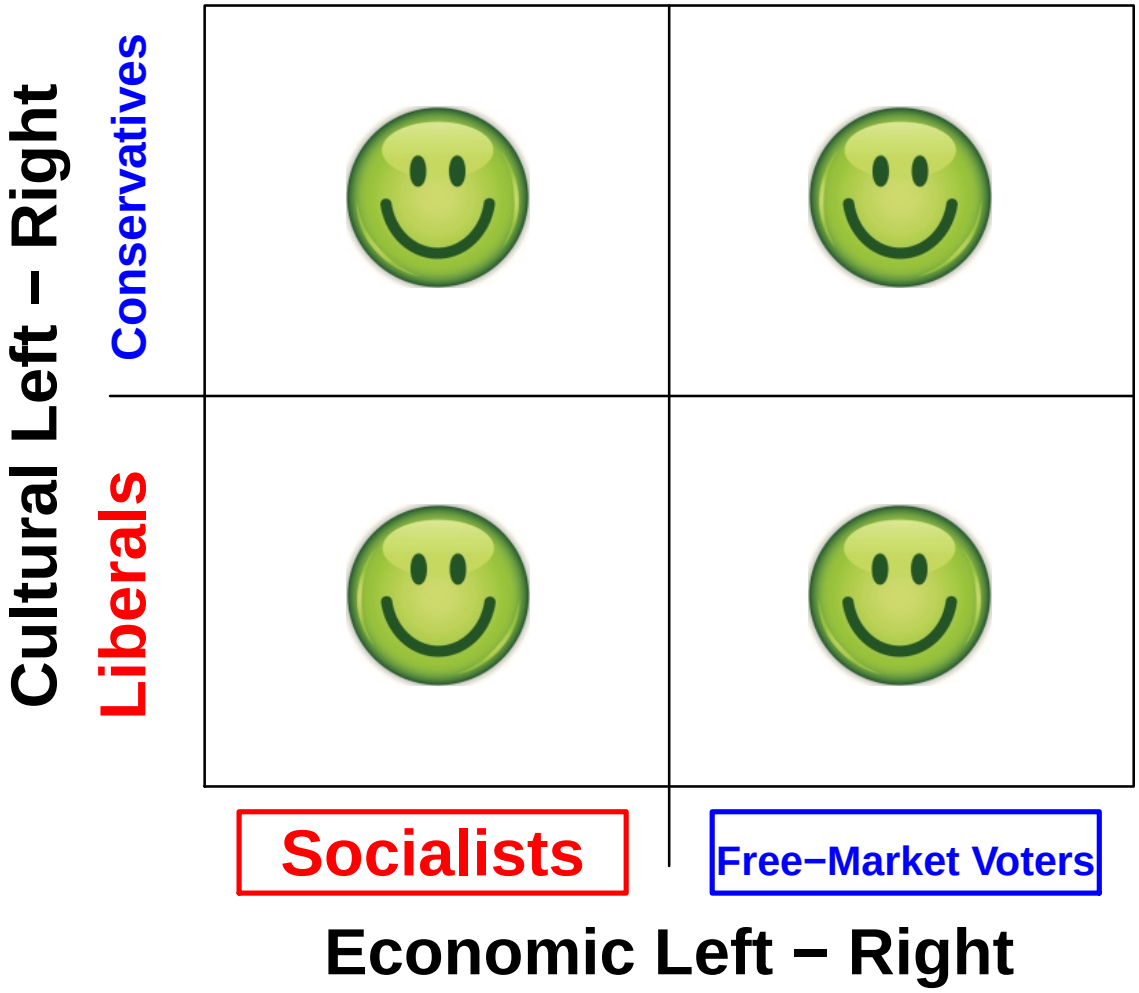
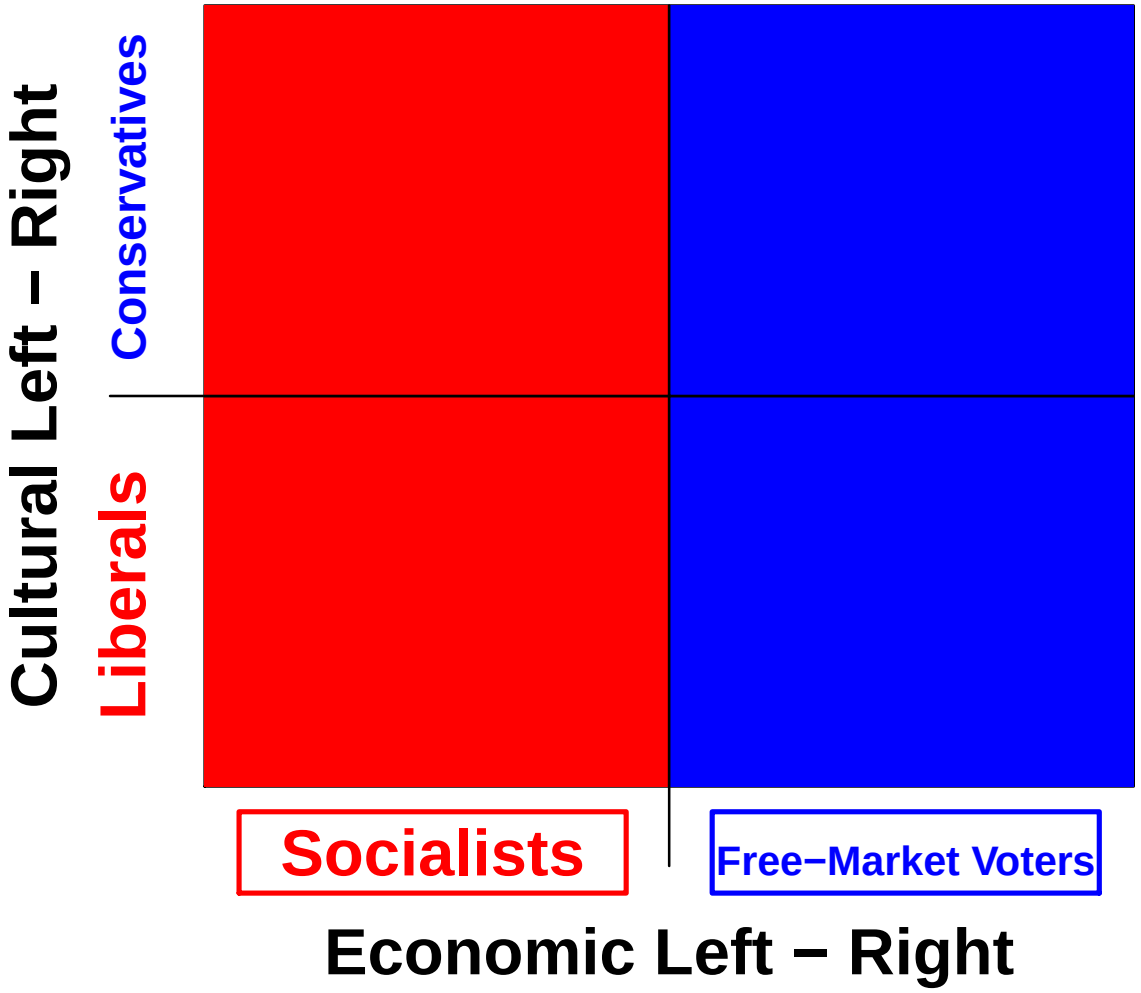
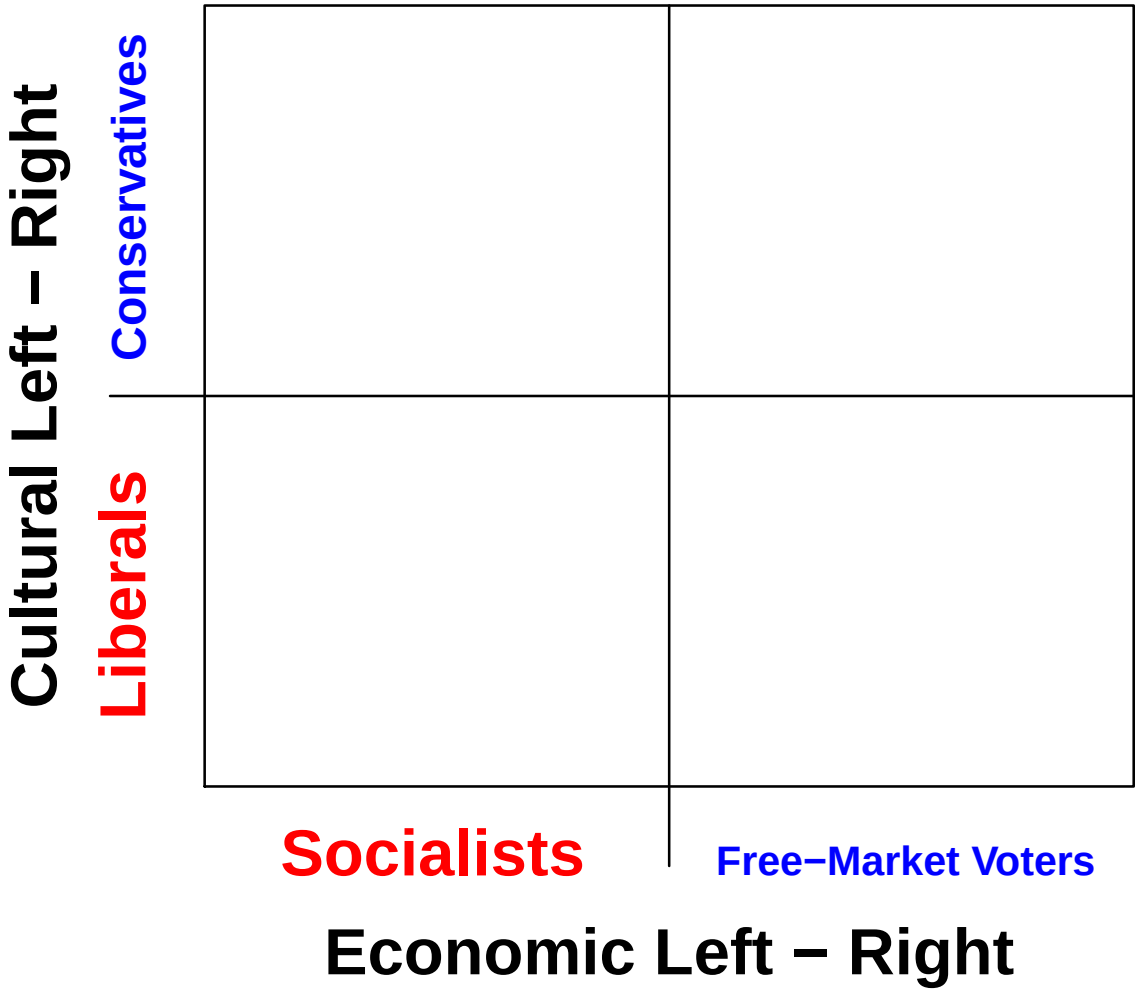


Policy Emphasis and Voter Preference



When Do the Nationalists Emerge?



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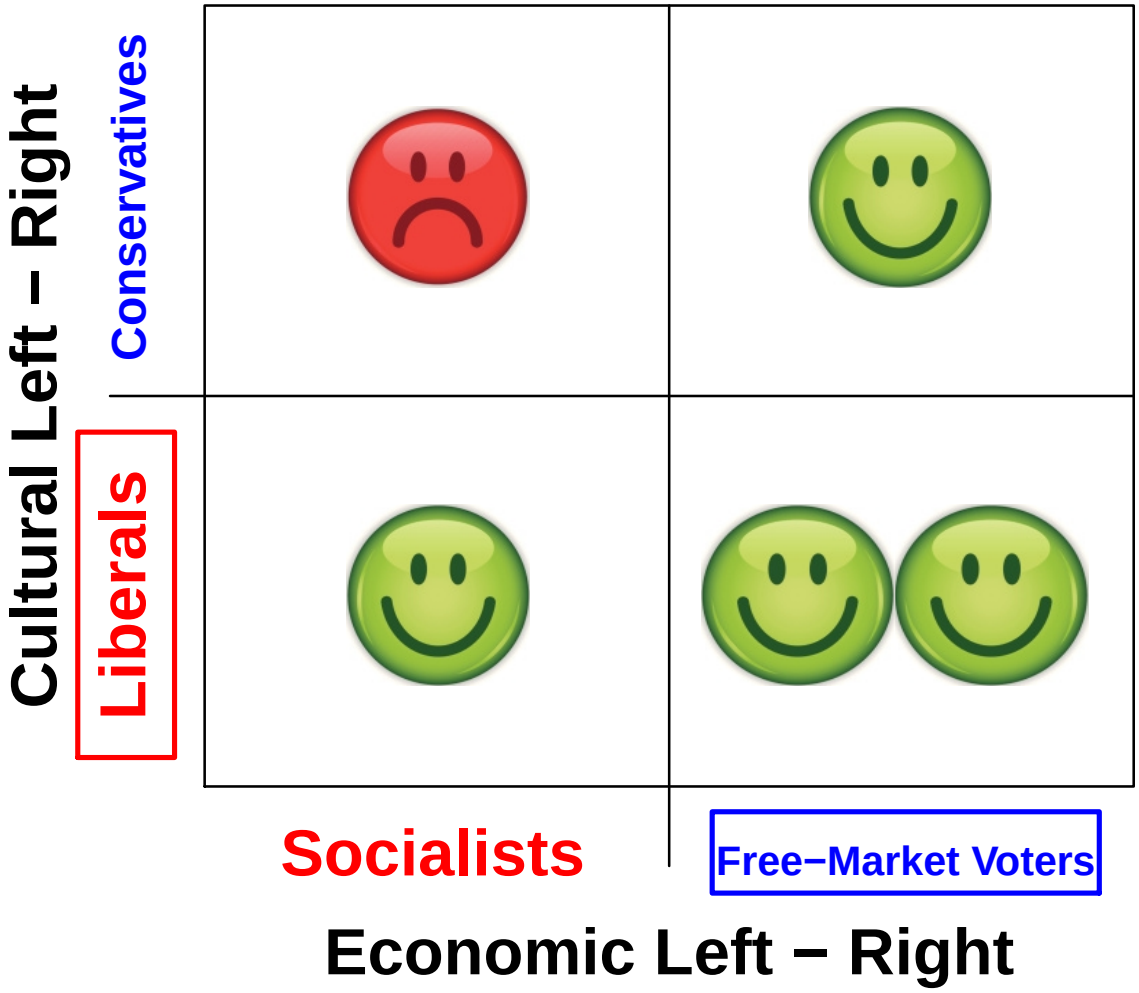


When Do Parties Target LF (and neglect CS)?

- The left emphasizes its liberal policies.
- The right emphasizes its free-market policies.

When Do Parties Target LF (and neglect CS)?

- When there are less conservative socialists (CS)
- When there are more liberal free-marketeers (LF)

$$\Downarrow$$

- The left emphasizes its liberal policies.
- The right emphasizes its free-market policies.

Sketch of the Model

1. Mainstream parties (L and R) decide issue emphasis: emphasis on economy relative to culture

2. Nationalists (N) decide to enter or not: enter if there are enough potential supporters

3. Four types of voters vote for the closest party: by respective weighted distance to each party

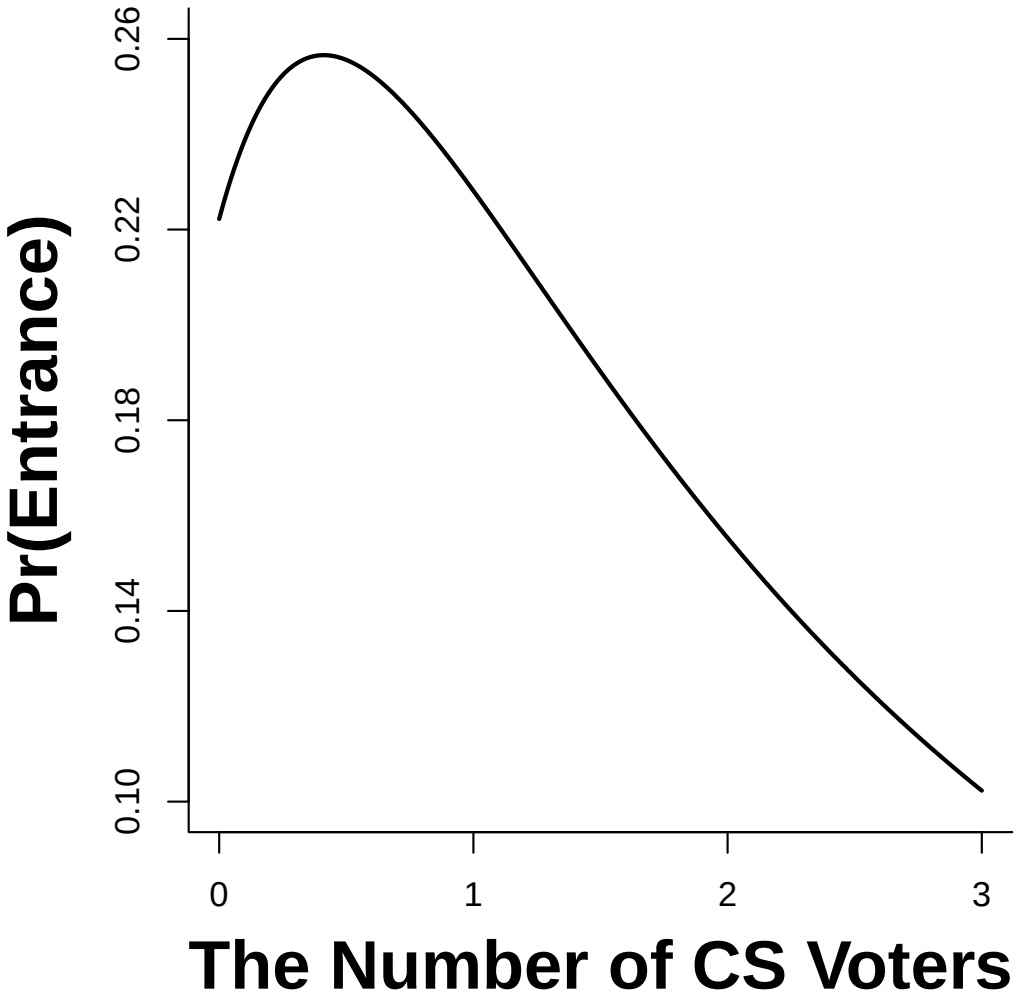
Proposition 1. There exists an interval where

$$\#\text{Conservative socialists} \Rightarrow \text{Probability of nationalist entrance}$$

$$\downarrow \qquad\qquad \uparrow$$

When Nationalists are Better Off with Less CS

$\theta = n/4$, $n_{(S,E)} = 1 \; \forall (S,E) \neq (1,0)$, $c_p = (\frac{2s_p - 1}{6})^2$



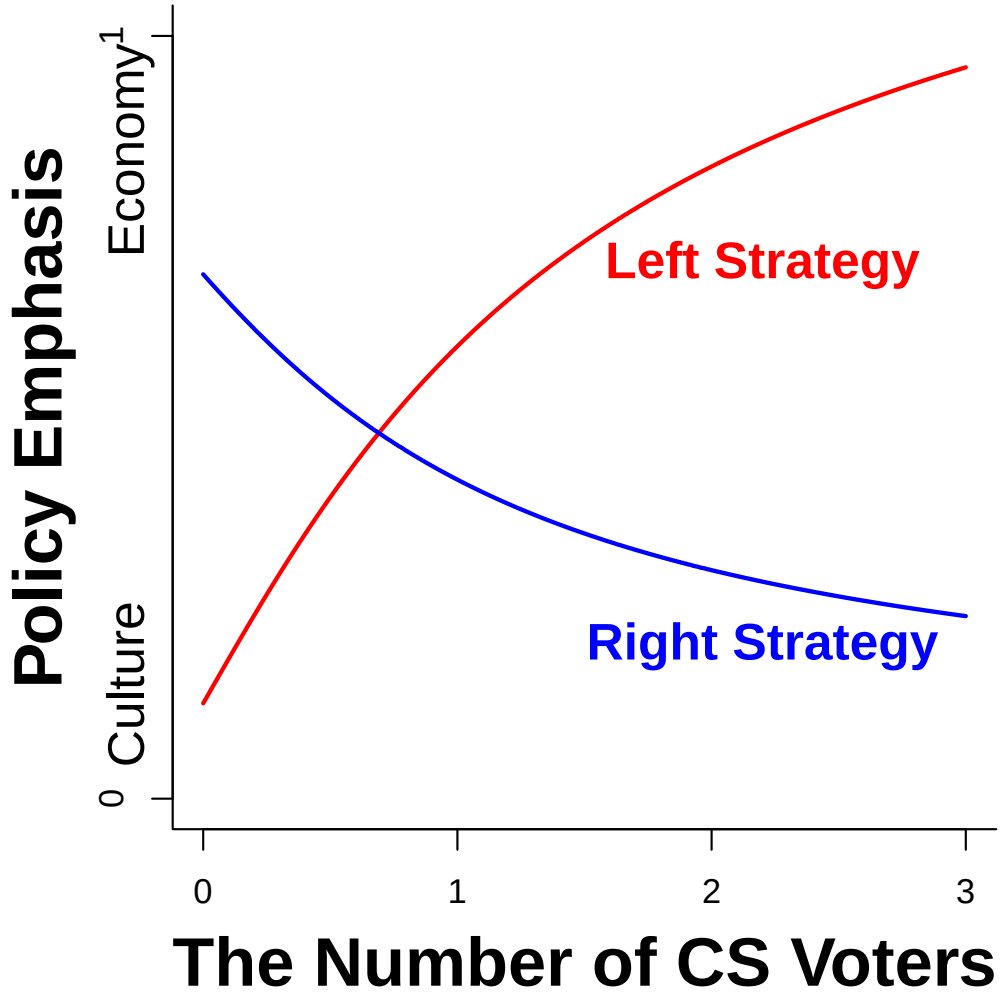
Two Forces Behind the Graph

(a) More CS $\Rightarrow$ More potential supporters for N $(+)$

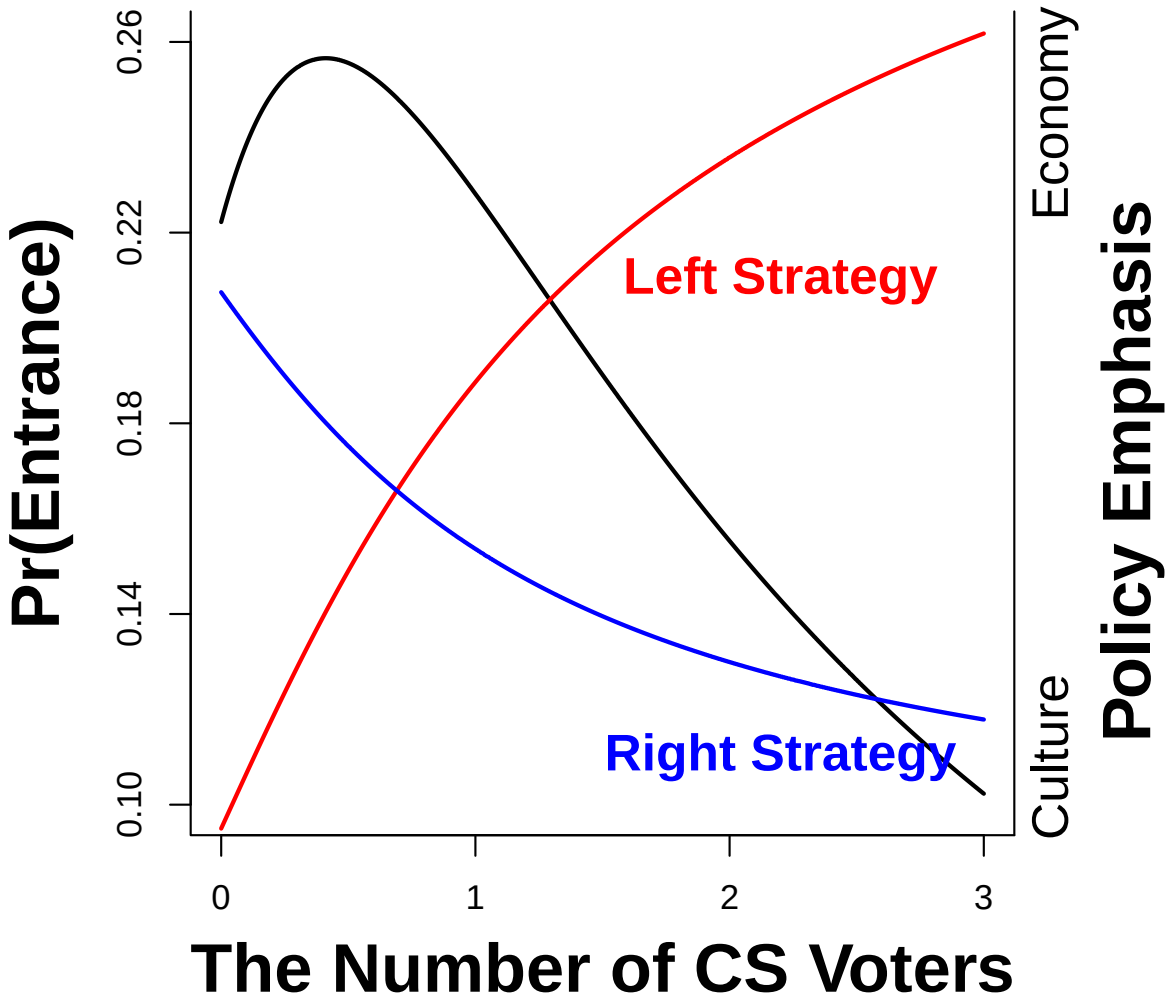
(b) More CS $\Rightarrow$ Parties more interested in CS $(-)$

The function is decreasing when (b)>(a)

When Nationalists are Better Off with Less CS



When Nationalists are Better Off with Less CS



Proposition 2. There exists an interval where

#Liberal free-market voters	$\Rightarrow$	Probability of nationalist entrance
$\uparrow$		$\uparrow$

When Nationalists are Better Off with More LF

- The reversed logic of proposition 1
- More LF $\Rightarrow$
  - the left targets liberals
  - the right targets free-market voters
- $\Rightarrow$ Unhappy conservative socialists
- $\Rightarrow$ Opportunity for the nationalist party

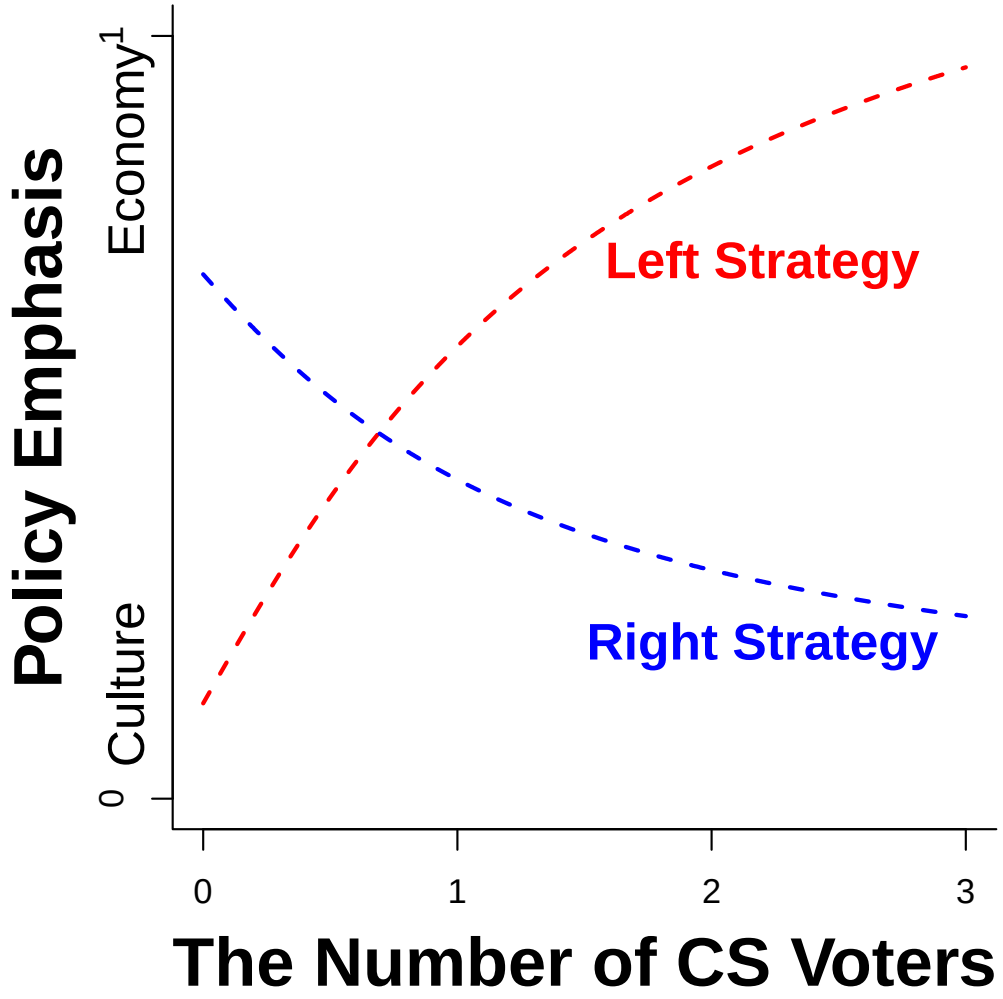
What Happens After the Entrance?

Corollary

If the nationalists compete in the election for sure ($q = 1$), the mainstream parties are more responsive to changes in voter distribution.

- Practically:
  Mainstream parties care more about CS once nationalists enter

What Happens After the Entrance?



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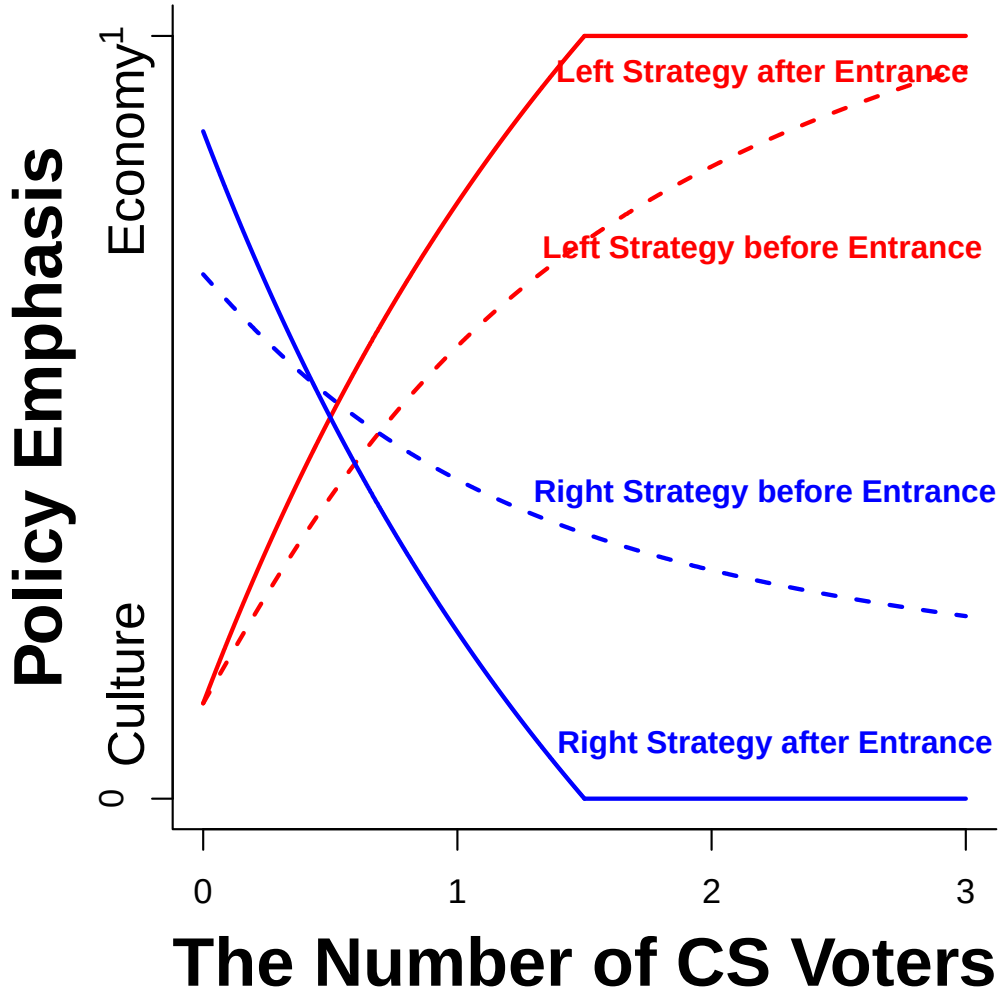
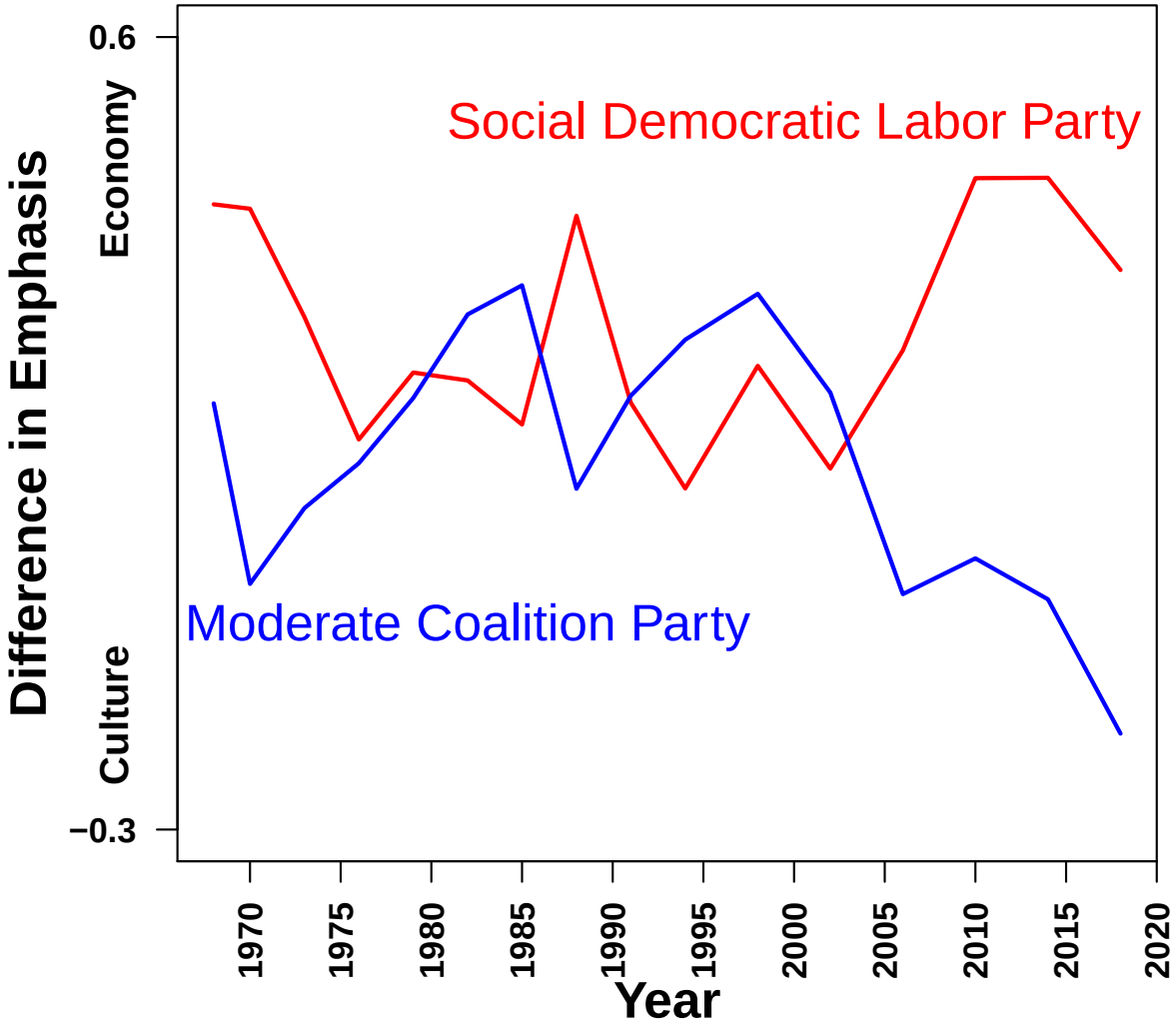


Swedish Case



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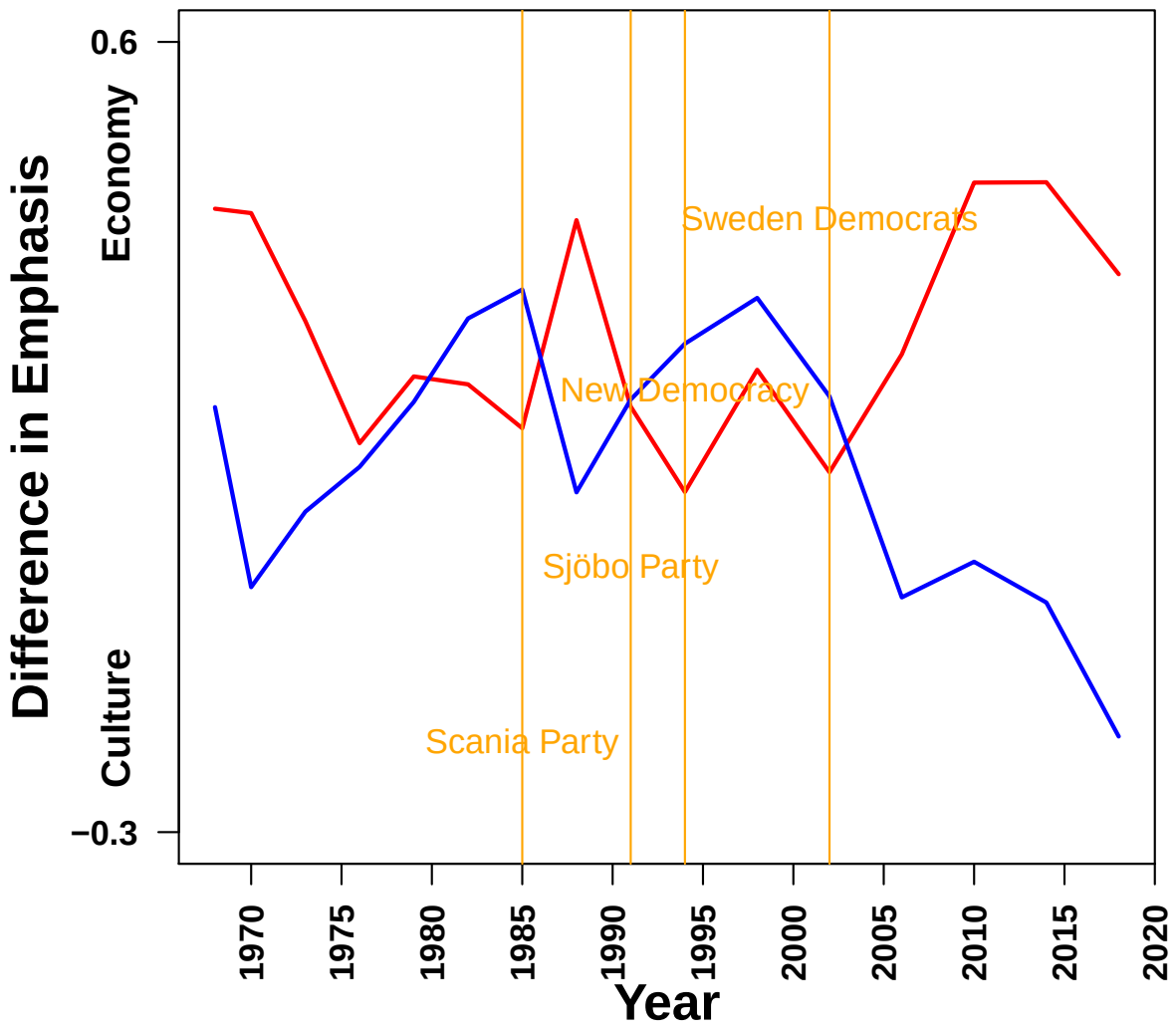


Summary

- Vote-maximizing parties encourage nationalist emergence in reponse to:

  ↑ Liberal free-market voters
  ↓ Conservative socialists

- In terms of class:

  ↑ Professionals
  ↓ Working class

Implication

- Policy-seeking left can inhibit nationalist growth

  - Policy distance between the left and the nationalists

  - Temptation to maximize vote share (Abou-Chadi 2019)

- The left is the key actor under a dilemma:

Tolerate nationalists

Tolerate nationalists

to maximize vote share

Give up liberal votes

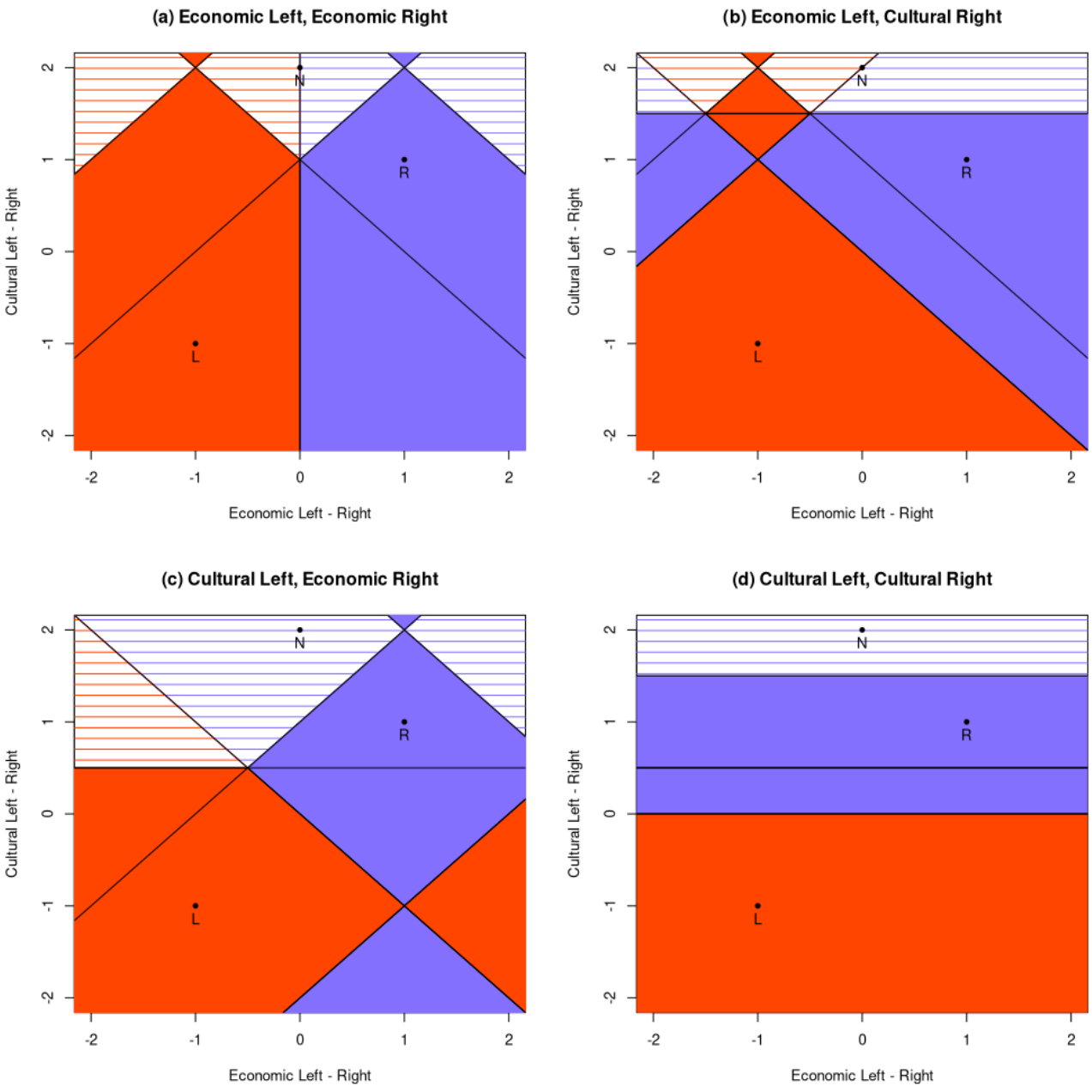
Give up liberal votes

to inhibit nationalist growth

Thank You

Appendix

- Setup of the Model
- $\mathbb{R}^2$ Policy Space
- Opinion on Immigration
- Swedish Case in Detail


(a) Economic Left, Economic Right
(b) Economic Left, Cultural Right
(c) Cultural Left, Economic Right
(d) Cultural Left, Cultural Right
Cultural Left - Right
Economic Left - Right
N
R
L
-2
-1
0
1
2

Setup

Voter Utility ($p \in \{0, 1\}$)

$u_{(S,E)}(p) =$

$u_{(S,E)}(p)$: The utility of a voter when voting for party p, if the voter's ideal social economic policy are $S \in \{0, 1\}$ and $E \in \{0, 1\}$.

Setup

Voter Utility ($p \in \{0, 1\}$)

$u_{(S,E)}(p) = -|p - E| - |p - S|$

p: Party. $p = 0$ for the left; $p = 1$ for the right

Setup

Voter Utility ($p \in \{0, 1\}$)

$u_{(S,E)}(p) = -s_p|p - E| - (1 - s_p)|p - S|$

$s_p \in [0, 1]$: Party p's emphasis on the economic policy relative to cultural policy.

At $s_p = 0$, p is a purely cultural party;
At $s_p = 1$, p is a purely economic party.

Setup

Voter Utility ($p \in \{0, 1\}$)

$$u_{(S,E)}(p) = -s_p|p - E| - (1 - s_p)|p - S| + (2p - 1)\epsilon$$

$\epsilon \in [-1, 1]$: Partisanship.

Higher ϵ: Partisan voter of the right
Lower ϵ: Partisan voter of the left

Setup

Voter Utility ($p = N$)

$u_{(S,E)}(N) = -|1 - S|$

Only cultural dimension matters for $p = N$(ationalist party);
Voters have no partisanship over the Nationalist party

Setup

Party Utility

$U_p =$

U_p: Party p's utility

Setup

Party Utility : Vote Share

$U_p = v_p$

v_p: Vote share of party p

Setup

Party Utility : Vote Share

$U_p = v_p$

v_p: Vote share of party p

= Sum of votes cast to p in each group (S, E)

$=\left(\sum_{i,j\in\{0,1\}} v_{[p,(i,j)]} n_{(i,j)}\right)/n$

Setup

Party Utility : Cost Function

$U_p = v_p - c_p$

c_p: the entrance cost if $p = N$ (the nationalists)

Setup

Party Utility : Cost Function

$U_p = v_p - c_p$

c_p: the entrance cost if $p = N$ (the nationalists)

$c_N \in [0, \theta]$

Setup

Party Utility : Cost Function

$U_p = v_p - c_p$

c_p: the advertisement cost if p is a mainstream party

$(p \in \{0, 1\})$

Setup

Party Utility : Cost Function

$U_p = v_p - c_p$

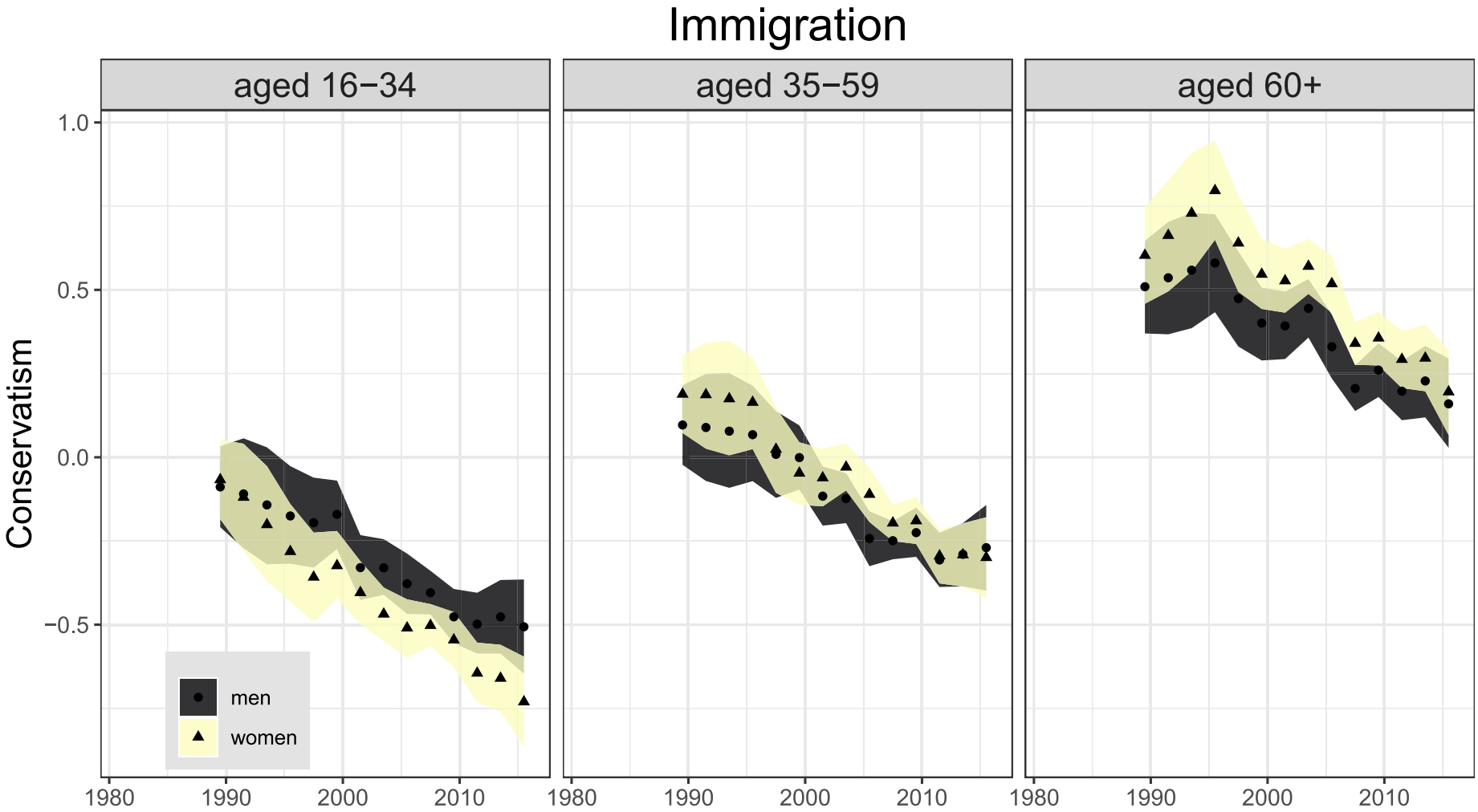
c_p: the advertisement cost if p is a mainstream party

$(p \in \{0, 1\})$

$-c_p$ is a concave function of s_p

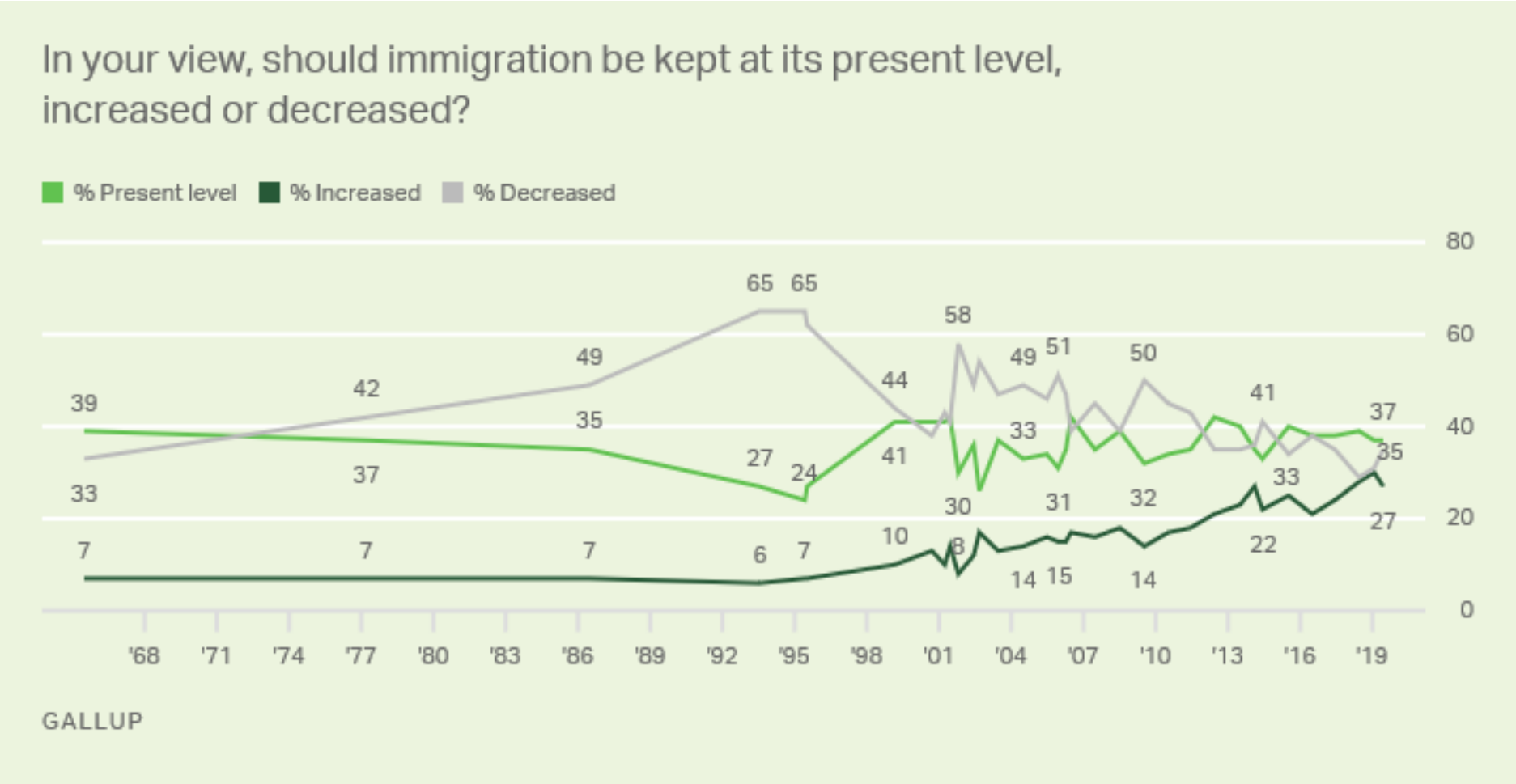
Maximum at $s_p = \frac{1}{2}$

Opinion on Immigration, Europe



Source: Caughey et al. 2019

Opinion on Immigration, the United States



Source: Gallup

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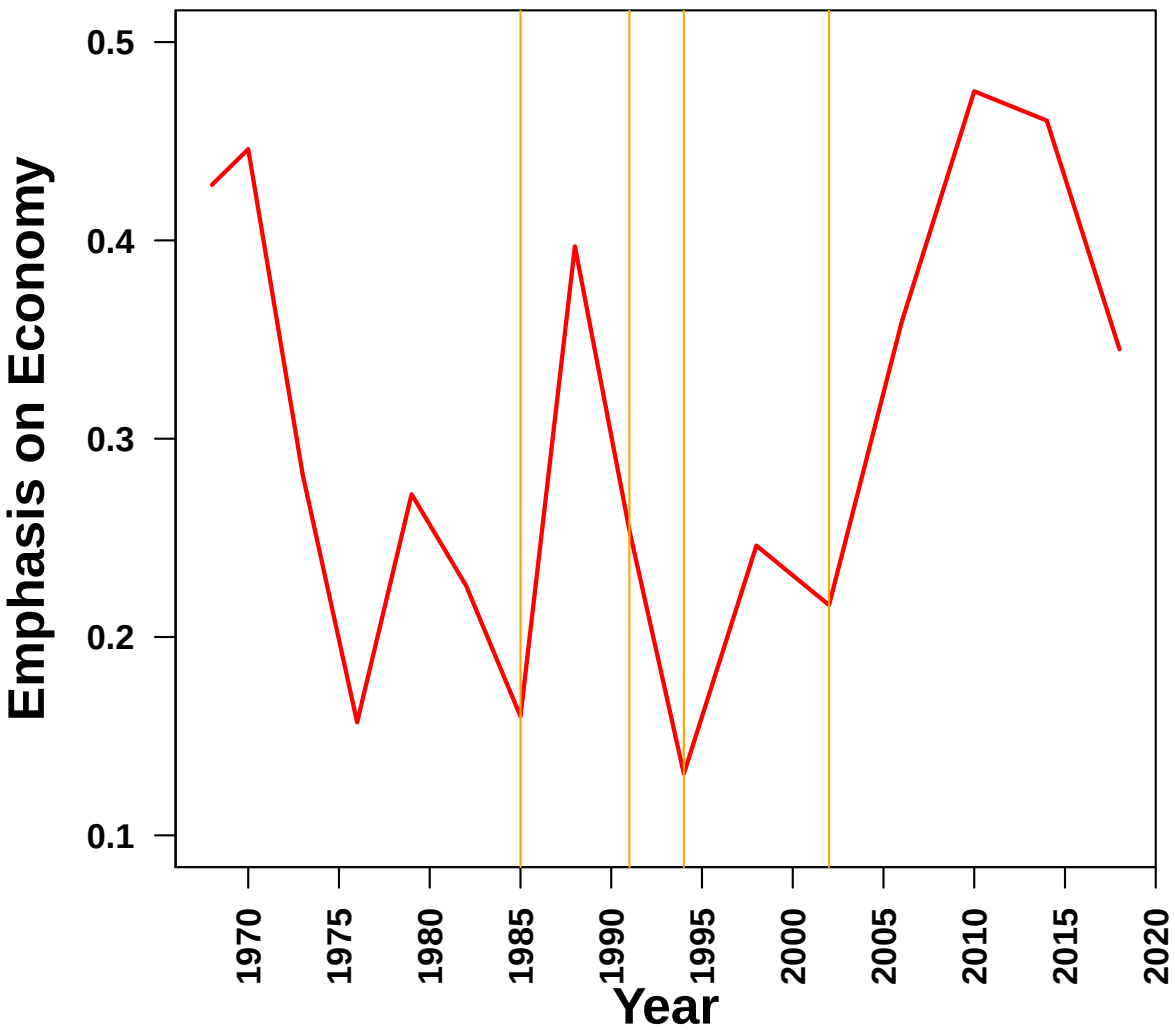

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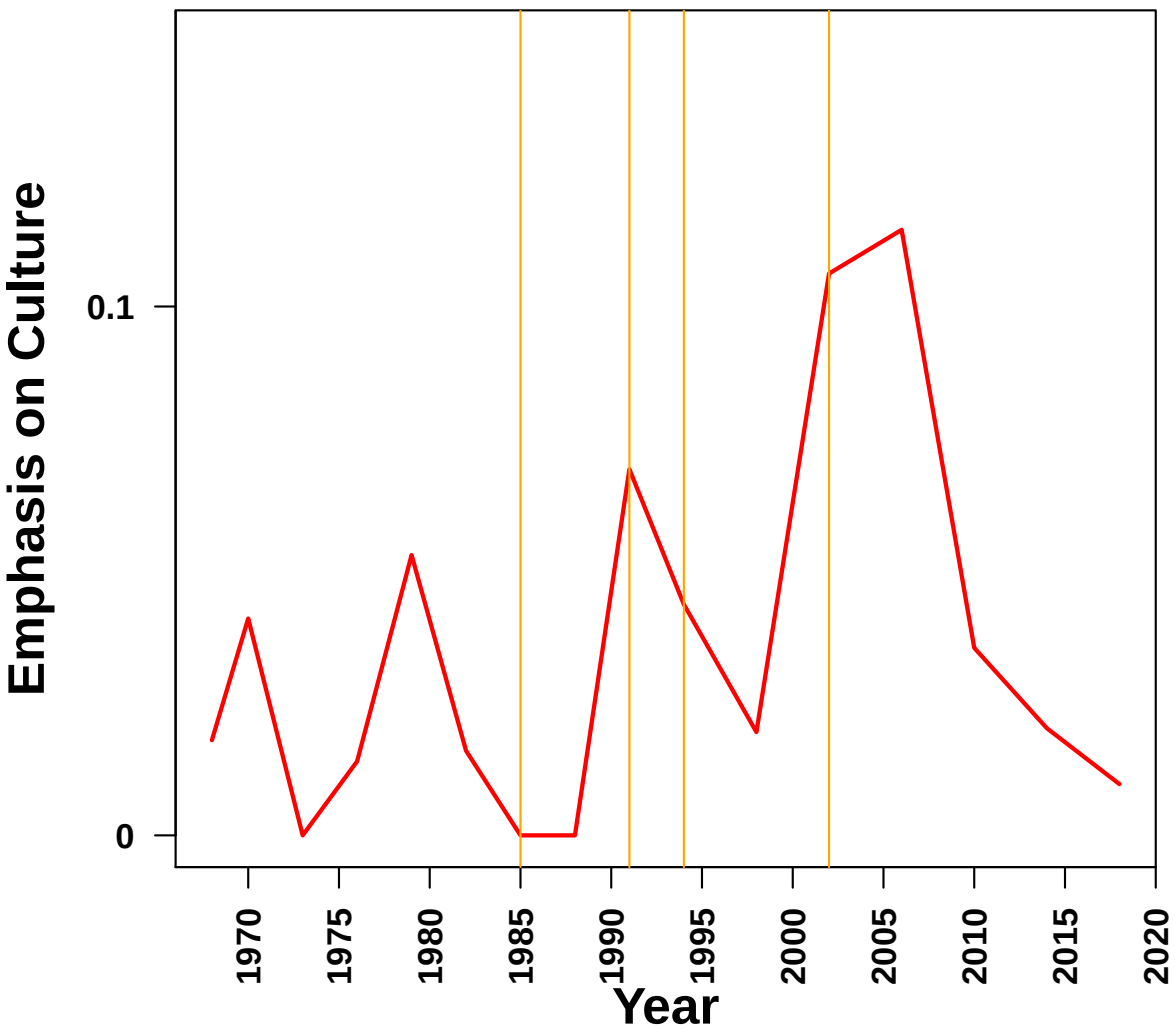

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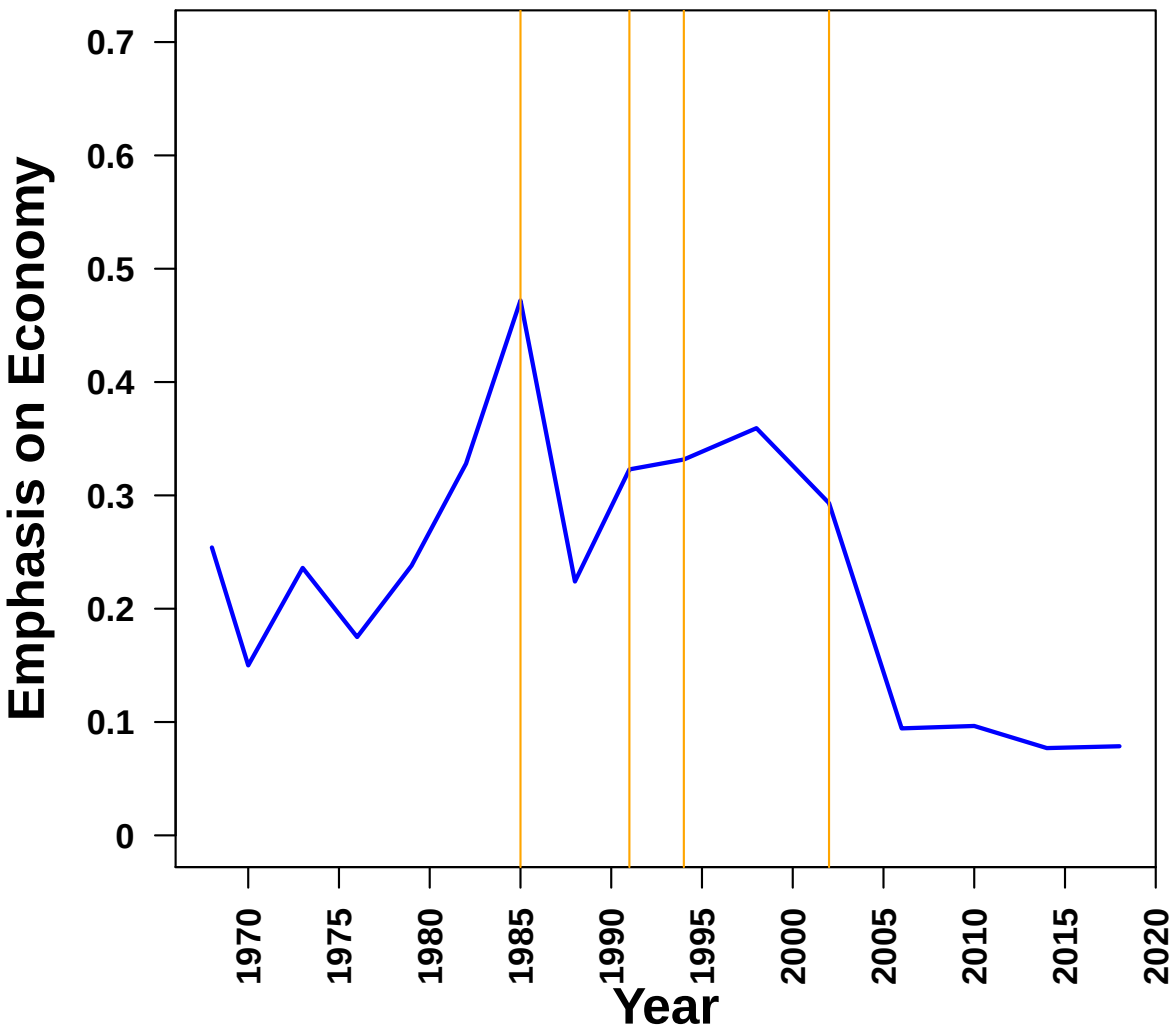
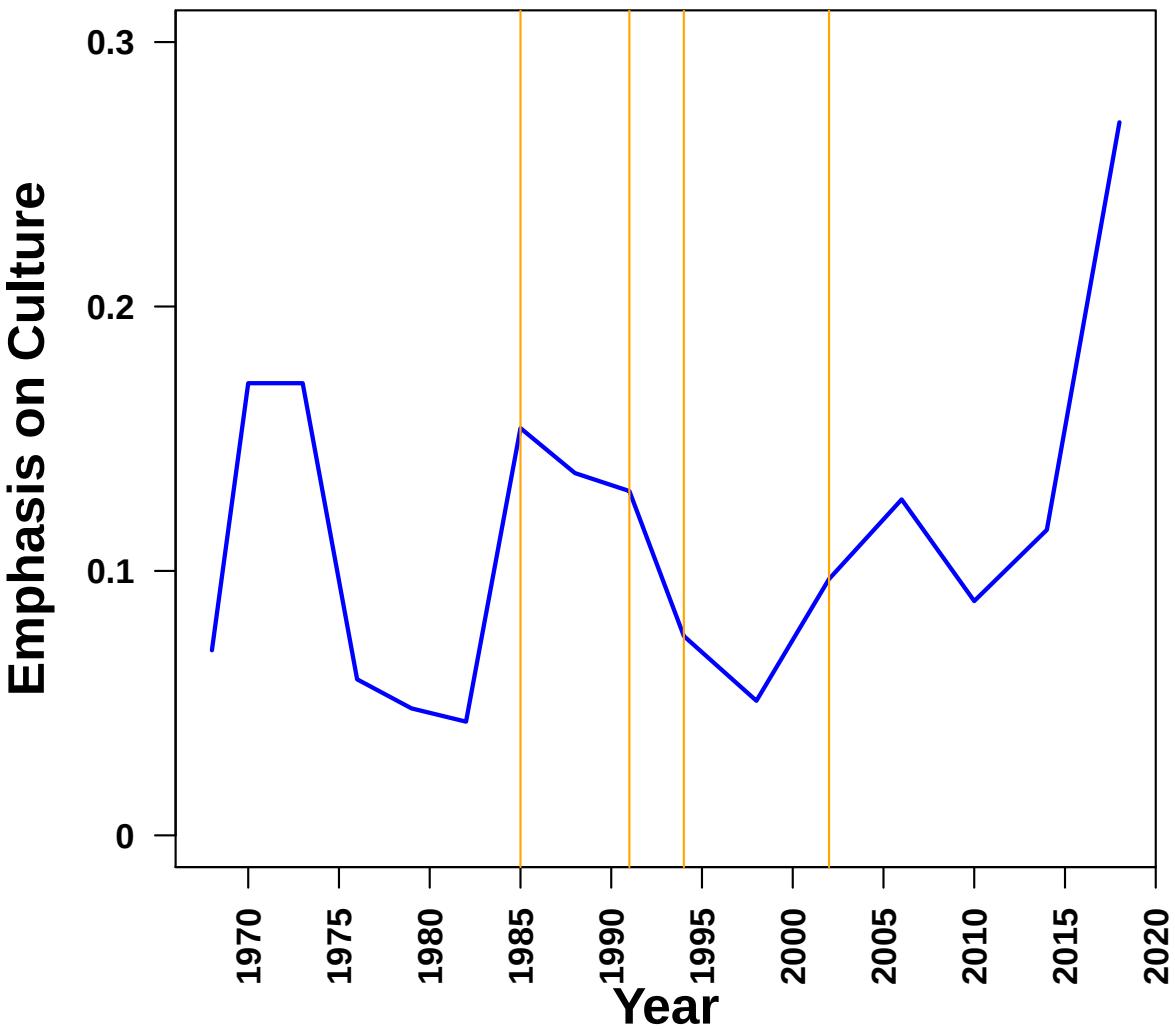
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